

WordPress Security Hardening Checklist

41-Point Lockdown

Almost every WordPress compromise traces to outdated plugins, weak credentials, or unrestricted file access. Close those three doors and you eliminate most of the risk.

What's inside

- Plugin and theme audit methodology
- User role and credential policy
- File permission and config hardening
- Backup and recovery verification
- Monitoring and alerting setup

Reduce Attack Surface

- 01 Delete deactivated plugins and themes — not just disable them
- 02 Replace abandoned plugins with maintained alternatives
- 03 Disable the file editor in wp-config
- 04 Remove default admin usernames

Access Control

- 01 Enforce two-factor authentication for every admin
- 02 Apply least privilege — most users need Editor, not Admin
- 03 Limit login attempts and rename the login path
- 04 Audit user accounts quarterly and remove leavers

Server & Config

- 01 Correct file permissions: 644 files, 755 directories
- 02 Move wp-config above web root where the host allows
- 03 Force HTTPS and enable HSTS
- 04 Disable XML-RPC unless a specific integration needs it

Recovery Readiness

- 01 Automated daily offsite backups with 30-day retention
- 02 Test a full restore at least once per quarter
- 03 Enable file integrity monitoring with alerts
- 04 Document the incident response steps before you need them

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inquiry@squadtechsol.com